which, in the early years of the Bolshevik Revolution, was strictly forbidden.

My father spent much of his time, therefore, having to prove that it was indeed a community endeavor and that the only money he drew out of it was for operating expenses. He also had to explain why Gentiles were not involved and succeeded in demonstrating that they had been invited to join but had refused to do so. And because he was clearly engaged in useful work, he was not called into the Red Army, and he continued to run the co-operative for five years.

My father also helped organize a library in the town and he and my mother took part in amateur theatricals. Apparently my mother had unexpected talent in this direction. According to my father: "Mamma learned her lines very easily. She did not depend on the prompter, who used to read in a low voice to keep the actors from making mistakes. Mamma did not need anybody's help. She learned the lines and did not make any mistakes. She was the best."

My father, who was an excellent reader 6 and who would read books aloud as part of his library work for those whose reading ability was limited, also took part in the plays but was, apparently, not as proficient as my mother at it.

According to my father, he and my mother "played as amateurs in more than ten plays and we were so good that they used to come to see us play from all the surrounding villages and towns."

There's no sign of anyone in my family having been a writer, though perhaps they might have been if the opportunity had come their way, but obviously both parents were used to being on the stage and must have had some talent for it.

I myself have never acted on the stage, but I do make a substantial part of my living as an after-dinner speaker, and I'm very good at it. 6 Apparently I come by it honestly.

My father says that toward the end she was acting at a time when she was "in the seventh month with a baby and nobody could have told that she was pregnant at that time."

That meant she was acting in the fall of 1919, for the baby she was carrying was I. That nobody could tell she was pregnant was probably

5 I can vouch for my father's ability in this respect, for he would, on rare occasions, recite, from memory, short stories of Sholem Aleichem (in